

**REFRAMING WOMANHOOD IN CONTEMPORARY NIGERIAN CINEMA:
A FEMINIST CONTENT AND DISCOURSE ANALYTICAL
APPROACH (2015-2025)**

BY

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Abstract

This study examines the reframing of womanhood in contemporary Nigerian cinema using a feminist content and discourse analytical approach (2015–2025). Anchored in Feminist Film Theory and Social Constructionist Theory, the research adopts an interpretivist philosophy and a qualitative design. A purposive sample of 60 Nollywood films, drawn from an estimated population of 1,200 films, was selected to ensure diversity in genre, narrative style, and production scale. Data were collected through qualitative content and discourse analysis, with attention to visual representation, narrative structures, and linguistic patterns, while thematic interpretive analysis was used to identify recurring patterns in the portrayal of women. Findings reveal that Nigerian films increasingly depict women as independent, professional, and socially influential actors, reflecting shifting societal expectations. However, these progressive portrayals coexist with underlying patriarchal discourses that continue to shape and sometimes constrain female agency. The study further demonstrates that cinematic content and discourse interact dynamically, simultaneously challenging and reinforcing traditional gender norms. It concludes that Nollywood has made notable progress in expanding representations of womanhood, positioning women as active agents of change while still negotiating cultural expectations. The study recommends that filmmakers sustain efforts to produce authentic and empowering narratives that reflect the diverse roles and contributions of women in contemporary society.

Keywords: *reframing womanhood, contemporary Nigerian cinema, feminist content, discourse analytical approach*

Introduction

Cinema occupies a central position in the construction, negotiation, and transformation of social meanings, particularly in relation to gender, identity, and power. As a cultural and ideological medium, film does not merely reflect reality but actively shapes how societies understand and define womanhood (Smith et al., 2023). Within global feminist film discourse, scholars have consistently highlighted the persistence of gender inequalities in cinematic narratives, where women are often marginalised, stereotyped, or framed through patriarchal lenses (Smith et al., 2023). However, emerging trends in contemporary cinema indicate a transition from static representation toward a more dynamic reframing of womanhood, where female identities are continuously renegotiated and reconstructed through evolving narrative and discursive strategies.

In the African context, this reframing process is particularly significant, as cinema operates within the tension between tradition and modernity. While African films frequently foreground women's lived experiences and community roles, they also reproduce cultural ideologies that

define acceptable gender behaviour (Gbambu et al., 2025). This duality creates a complex narrative space in which womanhood is not merely represented but actively redefined through competing cultural and ideological influences. Nigerian cinema, widely known as Nollywood, exemplifies this dynamic. As one of the most influential film industries globally, Nollywood has expanded its narrative scope and global reach, thereby shaping cultural perceptions of gender across diverse audiences (Financial Times, 2025). Within this evolving landscape, portrayals of women have shifted from rigid archetypes toward more complex and multidimensional identities that reflect changing societal realities (Worlu et al., 2025).

Despite these developments, the reframing of womanhood in Nollywood remains uneven and ideologically contested. Contemporary films increasingly construct women as independent, professional, and socially influential actors, signalling a progressive redefinition of female identity (Ilori et al., 2025). However, these constructions are often embedded within discursive frameworks that continue to reinforce patriarchal norms, moral expectations, and relational dependencies (Worlu et al., 2025). This creates a representational tension in which womanhood is simultaneously expanded and constrained, producing hybrid identities that merge empowerment with cultural conformity. The problem, therefore, lies not only in how women are portrayed but in how cinematic narratives and discourses reframe womanhood in ways that both challenge and sustain existing gender hierarchies. The absence of a systematic, feminist-driven analysis that integrates both content and discourse across a decade of Nigerian cinema has limited scholarly understanding of how these reframing processes operate within Nollywood (Gbambu et al., 2025; Ilori et al., 2025).

Addressing this gap, this study investigates how womanhood is being reframed in Nigerian cinema between 2015 and 2025 by examining the interaction between cinematic content and discourse. Specifically, the study seeks to examine how contemporary Nigerian films construct and reframe womanhood in terms of roles, identities, agency, and social positioning; determine the dominant discursive strategies through which meanings about women, power, and gender relations are negotiated; and ascertain how the interaction between content and discourse simultaneously challenges and reinforces traditional gender norms and patriarchal ideologies. By foregrounding reframing rather than mere representation, the study conceptualises womanhood as a fluid and socially constructed category, continuously reshaped through narrative practices, symbolic systems, and cultural negotiations within Nollywood.

Conceptual Framework

Reframing of Womanhood in Contemporary Nigerian Cinema

The reframing of womanhood in contemporary Nigerian cinema refers to the evolving ways female identity, roles, values, agency, and social meaning are constructed and communicated through film narratives. This concept moves beyond traditional representations of women as passive, dependent, or morally confined characters toward more complex portrayals that include leadership, independence, emotional depth, resilience, and social influence. Scholars argue that cinema functions as a symbolic space where society negotiates cultural meanings, making film a powerful platform for redefining gender identities and social expectations (Smith et al., 2023). In this sense, reframing womanhood involves not only visible changes in character roles but also deeper ideological shifts in how femininity, power, and autonomy are understood. In the Nigerian context, this reframing process reflects broader social transformations driven by

education, urbanisation, digital culture, and women's increased participation in public life. Contemporary Nollywood increasingly portrays women as professionals, decision-makers, political actors, and moral agents, signalling a departure from earlier stereotypes that confined women to domestic or romantic roles (Worlu et al., 2025). However, this reframing remains uneven and contested, as progressive images often coexist with narratives that subtly reinforce patriarchal values and gendered expectations. This tension makes womanhood not a fixed identity in cinema but a fluid construct shaped by cultural negotiations, ideological struggles, and changing social realities.

Feminist Content Representation

Feminist content representation refers to the visible and structural elements of film narratives that shape how women are portrayed, including character roles, plot positioning, occupational identities, decision-making power, dialogue prominence, and narrative agency. This concept focuses on what audiences see on screen, such as whether women appear as central protagonists, active problem-solvers, or symbolic figures within male-driven narratives. Feminist scholars argue that representational content influences public perception by normalising certain gender roles while marginalising others, making cinematic imagery a powerful tool in shaping social consciousness (Gbambu et al., 2025).

In Nigerian cinema, feminist content representation has evolved from rigid archetypes toward more diverse female identities that reflect contemporary social realities. Films increasingly depict women as entrepreneurs, political actors, educators, and leaders, suggesting a growing recognition of women's social contributions (Ilori et al., 2025). However, content representation alone does not guarantee ideological transformation, as empowered roles can still operate within narratives that privilege male authority or moralise female independence. This makes feminist content representation a critical but incomplete factor in the broader process of reframing womanhood.

Gendered Discursive Construction

Gendered discursive construction refers to the symbolic, linguistic, and narrative processes through which meaning about womanhood is created in cinema. This includes dialogue patterns, moral framing, symbolic imagery, narrative voice, character framing, and storytelling structures that communicate values, norms, and ideologies about gender. Discourse operates beneath surface content, shaping how audiences interpret women's actions, choices, and identities within film narratives (Smith et al., 2023).

In Nigerian cinema, gendered discourse often functions through moral language, cultural symbolism, and narrative positioning that subtly define what society considers acceptable or deviant female behaviour. Even when films portray strong female characters, discursive framing may still associate women's power with emotional instability, moral risk, or social disruption (Worlu et al., 2025). This shows that discourse does not merely reflect representation but actively constructs meaning, making it a central mechanism through which womanhood is ideologically shaped and socially interpreted.

Cultural Ideology

Cultural ideology refers to the shared belief systems, values, traditions, and moral frameworks

that influence how societies interpret gender roles and social behaviour. In film, cultural ideology acts as a lens through which narratives are created and understood, shaping what stories appear legitimate, acceptable, or controversial (Gbambu et al., 2025). This ideology influences both filmmakers' creative choices and audience reception, positioning culture as a powerful moderating force in gender representation.

In Nigeria, cultural ideology rooted in patriarchy, religion, tradition, and communal values continues to shape cinematic storytelling. Even progressive narratives often align with cultural expectations that prioritise family stability, male authority, and moral conformity (Ilori et al., 2025). As a moderator, cultural ideology can either strengthen feminist reframing or weaken it by filtering new representations through traditional value systems.

Industry Power Structure

Industry power structure refers to the control systems within film production, including ownership patterns, leadership roles, funding access, and creative authority. These structures determine whose voices dominate storytelling and whose perspectives remain marginalised (Smith et al., 2023). When male dominance characterises production spaces, gender representation often reflects male worldviews and priorities.

In Nollywood, increasing female participation in directing, writing, and producing has begun to shift narrative focus toward women's experiences (Ilori et al., 2025). However, institutional barriers and market pressures still shape content decisions, meaning that gender-progressive narratives often face commercial and structural constraints. This makes industry power structure a key moderating variable that influences how feminist content and discourse translate into meaningful reframing of womanhood.

Audience Reception and Interpretation

Audience reception refers to how viewers interpret, internalise, and respond to cinematic representations. Meaning in film does not exist only in production but also in consumption, where audiences negotiate messages based on personal beliefs, cultural background, and social experience (Smith et al., 2023). This makes audience interpretation a crucial mediator between representation and social impact.

In Nigerian society, diverse audiences interpret women's portrayals through lenses shaped by religion, tradition, education, and generational values. Progressive portrayals may inspire empowerment for some viewers while triggering resistance or moral anxiety in others (Worlu et al., 2025). As a moderating variable, audience reception determines whether reframed representations of womanhood lead to social transformation, cultural tension, or symbolic resistance.

Theoretical Framework

Feminist Film Theory

This theory was developed by Laura Mulvey (1975), holds that mainstream cinema constructs women primarily as visual objects of pleasure through the “male gaze,” positioning men as active subjects and women as passive objects of desire, with the core assumption that film language, narrative structures, and visual techniques systematically encode patriarchal

ideology; critics argue that the theory originally universalised female experience, underplayed race, culture, and audience agency, and focused excessively on Western cinema, yet, it remains highly relevant to this study because it provides a critical framework for analysing how Nigerian films visually and narratively construct womanhood, power relations, and female agency within patriarchal cultural structures (Mulvey, 1975; Smith et al., 2023).

Social Constructionist Theory

This theory was articulated by Peter L. Berger and Thomas Luckmann (1966), proposes that reality, identity, and meaning are socially produced through interaction, language, and symbolic systems, with the assumption that gender roles and womanhood are not biologically fixed but culturally constructed and continuously reproduced through institutions such as media and cinema; critics argue that the theory underplays material structures, power inequalities, and biological factors in shaping identity, but it remains central to this study because it explains how Nigerian cinema functions as a cultural institution that constructs, normalises, and redefines meanings of womanhood through narratives, discourse, and representation across time (Berger & Luckmann, 1966; Worlu et al., 2025).

Empirical Review

A study by Worlu et al. (2025), titled *Reframing Womanhood in Nigerian Cinema: Gender, Discourse, and Cultural Transformation*, examined how Nigerian films between 2010 and 2020 portrayed women in roles that combined traditional expectations with modern agency, with the objective of identifying shifts in female representation; the study employed a content and discourse analytical approach and found that while women were increasingly depicted as independent and strategic actors, underlying patriarchal discourses still moderated these portrayals, a finding similar to the current study's focus on analyzing both content and discourse to understand how womanhood is being reframed in Nigerian cinema from 2015 to 2025.

Ilori et al. (2025) conducted a study titled *Female Auteurs and Feminist Storytelling in Contemporary Nollywood Cinema*, with the objective of assessing how female directors influence the narratives and discursive constructions of women in Nigerian films; using qualitative interviews with filmmakers and textual film analysis, they found that films directed by women often foreground women's agency, leadership, and decision-making power, paralleling the current study's interest in exploring the interaction between cinematic content and discursive strategies to challenge or reinforce gender norms.

Gbambu et al. (2025), in their study *Gender Narratives and Female Representation in Contemporary African Cinema*, aimed to investigate the portrayal of women across select African films and identify how content and discourse contributed to shaping audience perceptions; employing a mixed-methods approach combining content analysis and audience reception surveys, they found that films presented women in multifaceted roles but that cultural ideologies and societal expectations strongly influenced audience interpretation, which aligns with the current study's consideration of cultural and discursive factors as moderators in understanding how Nollywood narratives reframe womanhood.

Literature Review/Gap Identification

Although existing studies have explored female representation in Nigerian and African cinema,

focusing on either content, discourse, or the influence of female directors, there remains a significant gap in systematically examining how womanhood is reframed across a full decade of Nollywood films from 2015 to 2025, integrating both content and discursive analyses while accounting for cultural, industrial, and audience influences; this gap limits understanding of the complex interplay between cinematic portrayals, societal ideologies, and audience interpretations in shaping contemporary conceptions of womanhood in Nigeria.

Methodology

This study adopted an interpretivist research philosophy, grounded in a feminist research approach, to critically examine how womanhood is reframed in contemporary Nigerian cinema between 2015 and 2025. A qualitative research design was employed to enable an in-depth exploration of both visible cinematic content and underlying discursive constructions of gender. The population comprised Nollywood films produced within the study period that featured significant female characters or were directed/produced by women, estimated at approximately 1,200 films based on records from the Nigerian Film Corporation and film distribution platforms. A purposive sampling technique, complemented by maximum variation sampling, was used to select 60 films that reflect diversity in genre, thematic focus, production scale, and audience reach. The sampled films included both mainstream and independent productions such as *The Wedding Party*, *King of Boys*, *Lionheart*, *Isoken*, *Omo Ghetto: The Saga*, *Citation*, *Blood Sisters*, *Aníkúlápó*, *Glamour Girls*, and *Shanty Town*, among others. These films were selected because they explicitly engage with women's roles, identities, agency, and socio-cultural positioning. The inclusion criteria ensured representation across romantic drama, political drama, comedy, epic, and action genres, as well as films directed by notable female filmmakers such as Kemi Adetiba and Funke Akindele.

Data were collected through qualitative content analysis and discourse analysis. The analytical process was conducted in three systematic stages. The first stage involved open coding, where each film was viewed multiple times to identify recurring patterns in character roles, occupational identities, narrative centrality, and visual framing. Scenes such as the corporate negotiation sequences in *King of Boys* and leadership portrayals in *Lionheart* were examined to identify how agency and authority were visually constructed. Codes such as “professional authority,” “relational dependency,” “moral framing,” and “symbolic power” were generated inductively.

The second stage involved axial coding, where initial codes were grouped into broader thematic categories reflecting patterns of reframing womanhood. At this stage, relationships between categories such as agency, cultural expectations, and narrative consequences were established. For example, in *Citation*, discursive elements such as courtroom dialogue and institutional power relations were linked to themes of resistance and gendered authority. The third stage involved selective coding and thematic integration, where core themes were refined and aligned with the theoretical frameworks. This stage enabled the identification of dominant discourses, including moral legitimisation of female power, relational negotiation of authority, and the coexistence of empowerment with patriarchal constraints.

To ensure systematic integration of content and discourse analysis, the study adopted a dual-layer analytical framework. Content analysis focused on observable elements such as character

roles, plot structure, costume, setting, and screen time, while discourse analysis examined dialogue, narrative voice, symbolism, and cinematic techniques such as camera angles and lighting. For instance, in *Blood Sisters*, visual depictions of female solidarity were analysed alongside dialogue that framed resistance and survival, demonstrating how meaning was constructed through the interaction of image and language. This integrative approach allowed the study to move beyond surface representation to uncover the ideological processes through which womanhood is reframed. Reliability was enhanced through repeated viewing, consistent coding procedures, and cross-comparison of themes across films. Reflexivity was maintained throughout the analysis to minimise researcher bias, ensuring that interpretations remained grounded in the data while being theoretically informed. Ethical considerations were carefully observed. The study relied solely on publicly available films, ensuring no infringement of intellectual property rights. All film texts were properly acknowledged, and interpretations were conducted with scholarly integrity and cultural sensitivity. Care was taken to avoid misrepresentation of filmmakers' intentions or cultural contexts, particularly when analysing sensitive themes such as gender inequality, power, and social norms. Additionally, the study maintained academic objectivity by critically engaging with both progressive and conservative portrayals without imposing subjective bias.

Overall, this methodological approach enabled a comprehensive and nuanced examination of how womanhood is reframed in Nollywood, capturing the interplay between visual representation and discursive meaning within a culturally embedded cinematic landscape.

Data Presentation and Analysis

Qualitative Data Analysis (Content and Discourse Analysis)

Data Presentation and Analysis (Film-Engaged Version)

Reframing Womanhood through Roles, Identities, Agency, and Social Positioning (2015–2025)

The analysis demonstrates that contemporary Nigerian cinema actively reframes womanhood by repositioning female characters as central agents within diverse socio-economic and political spaces, rather than merely representing them within traditional confines. This reframing is evident in films such as *Lionheart*, where the protagonist, Adaeze, is constructed as a competent corporate executive navigating a male-dominated business environment. Key scenes depicting boardroom negotiations and strategic decision-making visually and narratively encode female authority, thereby redefining womanhood as synonymous with leadership and professional competence.

Similarly, in *King of Boys*, the character of Eniola Salami embodies a complex reframing of womanhood through political power and moral ambiguity. The film's depiction of her rise within a patriarchal political structure challenges conventional gender roles, particularly in scenes where she commands loyalty and exercises control over male subordinates. However, the narrative simultaneously frames her power as precarious and morally contested, illustrating the tension between empowerment and societal judgement.

In *Isoken*, womanhood is reframed through the lens of personal autonomy and resistance to cultural expectations surrounding marriage. The protagonist's rejection of societal pressure to conform to traditional marital timelines reflects a shift toward individual agency, particularly in

scenes where dialogue explicitly challenges normative expectations of femininity. This reframing is further reinforced through narrative closure that prioritises self-fulfilment over social approval.

Films such as *Citation* extend this reframing into institutional spaces, where female agency is constructed through resistance to gendered power abuse. The courtroom and university settings serve as symbolic arenas in which womanhood is redefined as assertive, rights-conscious, and resistant to systemic oppression. The protagonist's confrontation with authority figures illustrates a discursive shift toward legitimising women's voices in spaces historically dominated by men.

In contrast, *The Wedding Party* and *Omo Ghetto: The Saga* reveal hybrid constructions of womanhood, where modern independence coexists with traditional relational expectations. While female characters exhibit confidence and social visibility, their identities remain partially anchored in romantic and familial roles, reflecting the coexistence of progressive and conservative gender narratives.

Dominant Discourses in the Reframing of Womanhood

The reframing of womanhood in Nollywood is not only evident in narrative content but is also deeply embedded in discursive practices, including dialogue, symbolism, and visual framing. In *Blood Sisters*, discourse surrounding female solidarity and survival is constructed through both dialogue and visual storytelling. Scenes depicting the protagonists' alliance against patriarchal violence reframe womanhood as collective resistance rather than individual vulnerability. The repeated use of assertive language and strategic silence reinforces themes of resilience and agency.

In *Glamour Girls*, however, discourse complicates this reframing by associating female independence with moral ambiguity. Dialogue and narrative framing often position economically empowered women within ethically questionable spaces, suggesting that female autonomy remains discursively negotiated within moral boundaries. This reflects an enduring cultural tension where empowerment is legitimised only under certain conditions.

The epic film *Anikulapo* provides a culturally grounded example of discursive reframing. Female characters are portrayed as influential within traditional structures, yet their power is mediated through cultural norms and symbolic roles. Dialogue and narrative progression reinforce the idea that womanhood is both powerful and culturally regulated, illustrating how indigenous narratives contribute to the reframing process.

Interaction between Content and Discourse in Reframing Gender Norms

The analysis further reveals that the reframing of womanhood emerges from the dynamic interaction between cinematic content and discourse. In *Shanty Town*, female characters occupy spaces of economic and social influence within a crime-driven environment. Visual content positions them as powerful actors, yet discourse often frames their agency within narratives of survival and moral compromise. This duality highlights how empowerment is constructed alongside vulnerability, reinforcing the complexity of reframed womanhood.

Films directed by female auteurs, such as Kemi Adetiba in *King of Boys* and Funke Akindele in

Omo Ghetto: The Saga, demonstrate a more deliberate alignment between content and discourse in reframing womanhood. These films foreground female perspectives through narrative centrality, assertive dialogue, and visual emphasis, thereby challenging traditional cinematic structures that marginalise women.

Across the sampled films, it becomes evident that Nollywood does not merely present static images of women but actively engages in a process of reframing womanhood through layered storytelling techniques. Visual representation, narrative structure, and discursive elements work together to construct meanings that both challenge and reproduce societal expectations. The reframing process is therefore neither linear nor uniform; it is a negotiated outcome shaped by cultural ideology, industry practices, and audience reception.

Ultimately, this analysis establishes that contemporary Nigerian cinema functions as a dynamic site where womanhood is continuously reconstructed. Through specific film texts and narrative strategies, Nollywood redefines female identity as multifaceted, context-dependent, and ideologically contested, reflecting broader transformations in Nigerian society while maintaining cultural continuity.

Discussion of Findings

How contemporary Nigerian films from 2015 to 2025 portrayed womanhood in terms of roles, identities, agency, and social positioning.

The study found that Nollywood increasingly depicted women as independent, professional, and socially influential actors, blending leadership, resilience, and relational responsibility while negotiating traditional expectations of femininity and moral authority. The study by Worlu et al. (2025) is relevant to the first finding because it documented the evolving portrayal of women in Nigerian cinema, highlighting how films increasingly positioned female characters in leadership, professional, and socially influential roles, which mirrors the current study's observation of women negotiating agency, identity, and relational responsibility on screen. The first finding, which showed that Nigerian films increasingly portrayed women as independent, professional, and socially influential, is supported by feminist film theory, as it highlights the importance of challenging the traditional “male gaze” and visually positioning women as active agents rather than passive objects, and by social constructionist theory, which explains that these portrayals reflect socially constructed meanings of womanhood that evolve over time through cultural narratives and interaction

Dominant discourses and narratives used to construct meanings about women, power, and gender relations.

The study revealed that filmmakers consistently employed dialogue, symbolism, and narrative framing to present women's authority as legitimate when aligned with moral and relational norms, highlighting a nuanced negotiation between empowerment and cultural conformity in Nigerian society. Ilori et al. (2025) is relevant to the second finding as it demonstrated that female directors actively shaped narratives and discourse to foreground women's power, strategic decision-making, and moral authority, providing a direct parallel to the current study's insight that dialogue, symbolism, and narrative framing consistently mediated empowerment within cultural norms. The second finding, revealing that filmmakers used dialogue, symbolism, and narrative framing to legitimize women's authority within moral and relational norms, is

underpinned by feminist film theory, which critiques how cinematic language constructs gendered power relations and highlights the ideological negotiation of female agency, and by social constructionist theory, which interprets these discursive strategies as socially mediated processes through which audiences internalize culturally acceptable roles for women

How cinematic content and discourse interacted to either reinforce or challenge traditional gender norms and patriarchal ideologies.

The study showed that Nollywood films simultaneously challenged patriarchal structures through progressive visual and narrative representations while subtly reinforcing existing norms through relational, symbolic, and narrative constraints, creating a dynamic space where empowerment, tradition, and audience interpretation intersected. Gbambu et al. (2025) is relevant to the third finding because their mixed-method analysis of African cinema showed that audience perception and cultural ideology interact with cinematic representation to either reinforce or challenge patriarchal norms, supporting the current study's conclusion that content and discourse in Nollywood simultaneously contest and sustain traditional gender ideologies. The third finding, showing that cinematic content and discourse simultaneously challenge and reinforce patriarchal norms, aligns with feminist film theory, as it demonstrates how film both resists and reproduces gender hierarchies through visual and narrative mechanisms, and with social constructionist theory, which posits that these interactions are part of a socially constructed reality where audience interpretation, cultural ideology, and symbolic representation together shape evolving understandings of womanhood

Conclusion

The study concluded that that contemporary Nigerian cinema between 2015 and 2025 has progressively expanded the representation of women, portraying them as autonomous, professional, and socially influential agents, which reflects Nollywood's capacity to reshape cultural understandings of womanhood beyond traditional domestic and relational roles

The study established that that dominant discourses and narrative strategies in Nollywood deliberately mediate women's authority through dialogue, symbolism, and plot construction, demonstrating that filmmakers negotiate empowerment within cultural and moral frameworks, thereby illustrating the intricate balance between feminist representation and societal expectations

The study justified that that the interplay between cinematic content and discourse creates a dynamic space in which Nollywood films simultaneously challenge and reinforce patriarchal norms, revealing that gender representation is neither uniform nor static but continuously negotiated through visual, narrative, and linguistic elements within the Nigerian socio-cultural context

Contribution to Knowledge

This study makes a significant contribution to Nollywood gender studies by advancing a more nuanced understanding of how womanhood is reframed, rather than merely represented, in contemporary Nigerian cinema. Conceptually, the study introduces the idea of “reframed womanhood” as a dynamic and negotiated construct, shaped by the continuous interaction between empowerment and cultural constraint. Unlike earlier studies that treat female portrayal

as static or descriptive, this research conceptualises womanhood as fluid, hybrid, and context-dependent, revealing how cinematic narratives simultaneously expand and regulate female agency within evolving socio-cultural realities.

Methodologically, the study contributes a dual-layer analytical framework that systematically integrates qualitative content analysis with discourse analysis. By examining both the visible elements of film (such as character roles, narrative positioning, and visual symbolism) and the underlying discursive mechanisms (including dialogue, moral framing, and narrative logic), the study moves beyond single-method approaches that dominate existing Nollywood gender research. This integrative method provides a more comprehensive tool for analysing how meaning is constructed in film, demonstrating that representation cannot be fully understood without interrogating the discursive processes that shape interpretation. In doing so, the study establishes a replicable model for future research in African cinema and media studies.

Theoretically, the study extends the application of Feminist Film Theory and Social Constructionist Theory within the Nigerian context by demonstrating how the “male gaze” and socially constructed gender meanings are not only reproduced but also reconfigured through local cultural narratives, industry dynamics, and audience expectations. It shows that Nollywood operates as a site of ideological negotiation where global feminist ideas intersect with indigenous cultural frameworks, thereby producing distinct forms of gender discourse that differ from Western cinematic traditions. This theoretical integration offers a context-sensitive reinterpretation of established frameworks, making them more applicable to African media environments.

Furthermore, the study provides new empirical insight by mapping decade-long shifts (2015–2025) in the interaction between cinematic content and discourse, highlighting how this interaction produces complex, and sometimes contradictory, constructions of womanhood. It demonstrates that while visual and narrative content increasingly positions women as leaders and decision-makers, discursive elements often mediate, legitimise, or constrain this empowerment through moral and relational expectations. This finding advances existing scholarship by showing that gender transformation in Nollywood is not linear but dialectical, involving simultaneous processes of resistance and reinforcement.

Overall, the study enriches Nollywood gender studies by offering a multidimensional framework that captures the interplay between content, discourse, and ideology. It moves the field beyond descriptive analyses of female representation toward a deeper interrogation of how cinematic meaning is produced, negotiated, and contested, thereby, opening new pathways for research on gender, media, and cultural transformation in Nigeria and beyond.

Recommendations

Based on the results of this study, the following recommendations were made:

1. Nollywood filmmakers and production houses should continue to create and promote narratives that portray women in leadership, professional, and socially influential roles, ensuring that character development reflects authentic agency and modern societal contributions.
2. Scriptwriters, directors, and cultural regulators should consciously employ dialogue,

symbolism, and narrative framing to legitimize women's authority and challenge restrictive cultural norms, while promoting storylines that balance empowerment with ethical and relational responsibility.

3. Film industry associations, academic institutions, and audience advocacy groups should collaborate to support content and discourse that actively challenges patriarchal structures, monitors gender representation, and encourages audience engagement with progressive narratives that redefine womanhood in Nigerian cinema.

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